In

2012, Shruti Malik Oberoi made a bold choice that reshaped her life and the lives of hundreds around her. After a successful stint at Sapient Nitro in Gurugram, she walked away from the corporate hustle and the city's maddening rush. Her heart was set on Yamunanagar, her hometown in Haryana, where she could live close to her loved ones and pursue work that carried deeper meaning. What looked like a retreat from ambition was, in fact, the start of an inspiring entrepreneurial journey. "I always wanted to impact lives, rather than doing a nine-to-five corporate job," says 35-year-old Shruti.

The best part was that her decision coincided with a national awakening for skill development. India was innovating aggressively to bridge the skill gap, with new programmes launched by the government and industry to prepare rural youths for modern jobs. Shruti spotted this wave early and pivoted into the skill development ecosystem. Thus was born Iris Learnings, an experiment in grassroots empowerment.

Starting small, she trained farm labourers to drive and repair tractors, then helped them buy their own under PM MUDRA Yojana, so they could support farmers with mechanised farming. Government schemes such as the Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Grameen Kaushalya Yojana (DDU-GKY) soon became key partners in her mission.

A decade later, Shruti's canvas had expanded. Now married, she leveraged the balance sheet of her husband's family enterprise—Oberoi Wood Products (OWP)—to deepen her impact. Alongside running Iris Learnings, she created a vertical within what was otherwise a plywood trading company. This time, her focus was on rural women from below poverty line (BPL) households. Today, OWP handles government scheme-linked programmes, while Iris develops skill initiatives for corporate houses. "In the government projects, the margins are thin, compliances are high. So, we decided to do it separately," Shruti explains. Through carefully designed training in high-demand roles—showroom host, computer operator, data entry operator, customer handling—she ensures that young women are not just trained but market-ready from day one.

What sets her initiative apart is its fully residential model. For three to four months, the girls live in hostels where lodging, food, uniforms and books are provided entirely free under government schemes. It removes financial burdens while nurturing independence, confidence and resilience.

The results have been transformative. So far, 280 rural girls have been trained, with 210 placed in companies such as Amazon, Flipkart, Royal Enfield, Hero MotoCorp, Blinkit as well as in leading BPOs. Through Iris Learnings, Shruti also tapped into the CSR (corporate social responsibility) ecosystem, partnering with Hero to train 910 girls, of whom 640 secured jobs. In all, her initiatives have touched more than 18,000 lives over the past decade.

Behind the numbers lie stories of courage and transformation. Take Varsha Kumari, a farmer's daughter from nearby Bhagwanpur village. Until she joined Shruti's programme, she had never stepped outside her village. Today, she works at Flipkart, earning Rs 14,000 a month. Her income not only supports her family but also funds her younger brother's education. Stories like Varsha's are living proof of what empowerment looks like when opportunity meets vision.

For Shruti, the journey is far from over. Her roadmap is clear: scale training programmes across states, expand placement pipelines and make eco-friendly livelihoods as accessible as they are aspirational. Her story is a reminder that real development begins not in boardrooms but when those at the margins are given the skills, confidence and dignity to rise. ■

FACT SHEET

Name of companies
Iris Learnings & OWP

What they do
Provide market-linked skill development for rural BPL youth, with a special focus on women

Founded in: 2012

Annual turnover
Rs 2.5 crore

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> **SHRUTI MALIK OBEROI**